

"I don't get the fuss, honestly," remarked Glumbo.

Borphyx does that kind of lukewarm half-half meh-meh thing with their six-fingered hand, where it kind of rotates left and right; you know the one.

"I mean, c'mon. Saucers are faster," Glumbo added, crossing their spindly gray arms.

"It's not *that* unfun, I enjoy the exuberant colors and comical allusions to familiar and popular media characters. Look at that one," Borphyx responds calmly, pointing at the large rotund plumber coming out of a larger, rotunder pipe in the not-so-distant scenery.

"It beats," Glumbo argued, wherein he would've scrunched his nose if he had one.

"Do you always have to be such a glorping pessimist dude? Seriously, what's your issue? It's a roller coaster. The humans made it for us. It was their welcoming gift. Holllllly phynx dude, I can't with you sometimes. You seriously take all the joy out of travelling to extragalactic worlds. I bet you'd rather have gone to Geochunk-9946. You know what that planet is? Guess what: a giant desolate wasteland of hollow regolith tunnels that have nothing better to do but to collapse in on themselves, wherein the resulting earthquakes then, purposelessly, create more hollow tunnels. You want something that beats? *That* beats."

Glumbo oscillates the purple bulb in the back of his throat in that way only his species can, and the air suddenly smells of something resembling pickled herrings. The kind made with vinegar, not mustard.

Borphyx gets the vibe.

"I just want to have fun," Borphyx throws out defensively.

The two, sitting side-by-side on their own blazing red car linked in a chain to the others just like it on the roller coaster, scoot apart from one another. It seems unclear whether their focus is on one another, or the speeding sights in front of them. Borphyx quite literally has one eye on each.

“I remember you like to have fun. I remember now. I had nearly left that memory sphere at home, but now I recall. I’m sorry Borphyx. You may enjoy the customary roller coaster ride of humanity’s so-called Extraterrestrial Greeting Amusement Funtime Ride. But I think I, too, should be allowed to voice my opinion spheres. Do you proffer an agreement sphere?” Glumbo communicates meaningfully, something sort of akin to forgiveness dancing across his vacant eyes.

“Yeah, I guess you’re—woah, holy glorp, did you see that?! When the coaster did a loop that guy just fell out! Are these safety bars not equipped to secure liquid-based lifeforms? This is terrible!” Borphyx shouted.

“What the phynx? Is that motherglorper going to be alright?!” Glumbo asks, grabbing Borphyx’s scaly arm as his already impressively wide eyes manage to widen.

“I used to believe these humans had our best interests in mind. Now, uh, I’m not so sure. I mean, look at that ooze little dude. Just a big puddle of slime down there now. Is he glowing? It doesn’t look like he’s glowing. I’m pretty sure he’s supposed to be glowing when he’s, y’know, alive.”

Somewhere down below, a janitor pushes a giant chrome cart full of odd machinery. It looks like a massive vacuum cleaner, if a vacuum cleaner was adorned with all the flashing lights the 1990s were convinced the 2010s would have. It was attached to a

canister, on a separate cart pushed by a separate janitor. That canister was like a giant glass bottle of frosty milk.

“Are they going to suck him up and put him in that canister?” asks Glumbo, the closest thing to shock he can manage in his voice leaking out.

Borphyx starts pushing on the safety bar that kept the pair in the roller coaster car. He lifts it up gently, testing its stability. It seemed to be locked in place; which was good. Right?

“Listen. I don’t think you need to worry about our safety, we’re not liquids. Sometimes accidents happen, even on mediumcore gently baby-rides like this. One time, when I was guiding my saucer through the lesser orbit of a poorly documented dwarf planet, the lid to my saucer flew open and my entire family got sent flying out because they forgot to buckle their saucer-belts.

“They all went flying, and I saw them collide with that dwarf planet. They’re probably ancient fossilized remains deep beneath the mantle of that poorly documented ghost planet now, and given time relativity with the nearest star, they have been on that planet for centuries. By the time I got the lid shut again, my entire life had just restarted.

“But did I mind? No. Because I’m aware that sometimes things like that just happen. And you have to treat that ooze down there the same way. What’s important, like you said before, is you having fun.” Glumbo started rattling off, hoping to encourage his friend.

“I never knew that, Glumbo,” Borphyx said, releasing lots of foul-smelling gas from various pores. This was, of course, how his species cried. “That’s a very moving story. I’ll be sure to have the most fun on this roller coaster ride possible now.”

Glumbo patted his hand; still six-fingered; on Borphyx’s grotesque, spiked, tangled, malnourished, frightening back. As he does so, he makes soft cooing sounds from a hidden orifice under his armpits.

The pair had learned a lesson that day: the universe is too big and beautiful a place to waste life.